



△ Tumble-polished rhodonite gemstone

Rhodonite

Rhodonite takes its name from the Greek *rhodon*, meaning “rose”. It is a source of manganese and is relatively widespread, but it is usually mined as a semi-precious gem and ornamental stone. It is typically a pink colour; however, material streaked with black veins is also favoured by carvers and cutters. Massive rhodonite is relatively tough, and so is excellent for carving; it is primarily cut *en cabochon* for gems and as beads. Transparent crystals are sometimes found, but they must be faceted with great care, and are strictly for collectors.

Specification

Chemical name	Manganese, calcium silicate	Formula	(Mn,Fe,Mg,Ca)SiO ₃
Colours	Pink to rose-red	Structure	Triclinic
Hardness	5.5–6.5	SG	3.4–3.7
RI	1.72–1.76	Lustre	Vitreous
Streak	White	Locations	Brazil, Canada, Sweden, Russia, England, USA



Rhodonite crystals | Rough | In this specimen, well-developed rhodonite crystals rest on a rock groundmass; crystals such as these are rare.

Granular surface



Rhodonite rough | Colour variety | This rough specimen of finest-quality rhodonite displays a typical granular form and a superb colour.



Rhodonite cabochon | Colour variety | Material with black veins and streaks, as seen in this cabochon, is favoured by some cutters over the solid rose colour.

Finely carved, smooth surface

Quartz layering



Rhodonite box | Carved | This spectacular decorative box has been carved from rhodonite that is black-streaked and interlayered with inclusions of quartz.

Rhodonite bear | Carved | This black-streaked rhodonite carving of a bear catching a salmon was created in a German gem-cutting centre.

Black veining



Unusually large crystals of rhodonite have been discovered in Franklin, New Jersey, USA



Walking stick | Carved | This head of a walking stick has been carved from fine rhodonite, and is decorated with a platinum royal monogram inset with diamonds.